Gender Norms and Household Responses to Economic Shocks

Isabel Di Tella & Martina Uccioli *

2 November 2025

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Abstract

Do gender norms lead to an inefficient reallocation of resources? This study investigates the role of gender norms in household reactions to major economic shocks. By leveraging rich longitudinal data on couples' employment, time use, and self-reported gender norms, we examine how employment shocks affect household resource allocation; in particular, testing whether gender norms impede changes towards income-maximizing arrangements. In the UK, we find that men are more likely than women to return to work in the long run after a layoff, but this asymmetry is fully concentrated among women who subscribe to traditional gender norms: progressive women have the same labor market response to a layoff as men. We plan to use the estimates to inform a search-and matching model, to quantify the role of gender norms-induced frictions in the speed of recovery after economic downturns.

* Di Tella: Massachusetts Institute of Technology, iditella@mit.edu. Uccioli: University of Nottingham, Cesifo, and IZA, martina.uccioli@nottingham.ac.uk. This work was supported by the Centre for Inclusive Trade Policy Innovation Fund, ESRC [grant number ES/W002434/1]. We thank the participant to the Public Finance Lunch at MIT, the Nottingham Brown Bag Seminar, and the Centre for Inclusive Trade Policy Innovation Seminar, as well as the participant to the Gender in the Global Economy at Barnard College (Columbia University), the Mend the Gender Gap workshop (Bocconi, EIEF, World Bank), the Nottingham Interdisciplinary Centre for Economic and Political Research (NICEP) 2025 annual conference, and the Midlands Empirical Economics Workshop for helpful comments. We are grateful to Juan Siachoque, Sagarika Sengupta, Thomas Wood, and Ahan Thakur for excellent research assistance.

1 Introduction

Men and women in the labor market look more similar than ever before. However, gender norms persist: evidence abounds of gendered patterns in couples' time use, even when financially sub-optimal (Ichino et al., 2024; Giommoni and Rubolino, 2022; Siminski and Yetsenga, 2022; Jessen et al., 2024; Andresen and Nix, 2022; Bertrand et al., 2015; Hancock et al., 2024). But do the same norms that bring households to deviate from income maximization also shape how they cope with large shocks, such as losing one's job?

The answer is potentially macro-relevant. During the first months of Covid-19, job losses were heavier among women than men: commentators dubbed the episode a "she-cession" (Alon et al., 2022). If women hit by the recession are more likely to retreat in home production, this might alter the speed of recovery: in this case, aggregate employment dynamics would depend not only on how many jobs are lost, but also on which spouse loses them and on the couples underlying views about breadwinning and caregiving. Yet the literature has little evidence on whether large, involuntary separations actually trigger gender-asymmetric adjustments inside the household, and none on whether any asymmetry is stronger in norm-conservative families, or on any resulting aggregate implications.

This paper fills this gap. Using rich longitudinal data from the UK, we first track what happens to a heterosexual couple when one partner is laid off: we find similar responses in the short run regardless of whether it is the man or the woman being laid off, but sharp asymmetric responses in the long run, with women twice as likely to remain out of employment and keep a higher load of home production five to ten years later. This asymmetry is fully concentrated among traditional women: progressive women have the same labor market responses to layoffs as men. Second, we embed these asymmetric responses in a search-and-matching model, and use it to quantify the role of gender norms in the speed of recovery from recessions.

In a simple framework of joint household decision making, we map spouses' labor supply, home production, and gender norms. Following Ichino et al. (2024), a couple's utility is derived both from consumption, purchased on the market with income earned from paid work, and a common good, produced via the time both partners spend in home production. Gender norms enter through the elasticity of substitution between women's and men's home-production hours, as well as its symmetry. A symmetric, high elasticity of substitution characterizes “progressive” couples in which the two inputs are easily substituted - either partner can take over domestic tasks with little loss of efficiency. An asymmetric, low elasticity of substitution describes “traditional” couples, in which inputs are near complements; here, reallocating domestic tasks from the wife to the husband is costly because it clashes with internalized gender roles. When an adverse labor market shock or a positive labor market opportunity affects one partner, progressive couples can shift time seamlessly from home to market activity (or vice-versa), preserving or increasing the amount of consumption and of the public good; in contrast, traditional couples cannot, and the household ends up away from the income-maximizing allocation.

A testable implications of the model is that, if gender norms did not matter, we would see the same households’ responses to the same economic shock irrespectively of whether it’s the man or the woman receiving the shock and irrespectively of revealed gender norms. We test this implication empirically: formally, we estimate both own and partner’s response to a layoff, separately between households in which the person being laid off is the man or the woman, and heterogeneously by revealed gender norms.

The primary data source for this study is the Understanding Society survey, a longitudinal household survey conducted in the United Kingdom since 1991 (University of Essex, Institute for Social and Economic Research, 2024). This nationally representative panel follows individuals and households over time, collecting detailed information on employment, time use, income, and attitudes toward gender roles. The survey includes all household members, allowing for a comprehensive analysis of intra-household dynamics. The Understanding Society dataset also includes questions about gender norms, which we use to construct a “progressiveness index” to classify individuals. This feature is critical for investigating whether the rigidity of gender norms influences household responses to shocks. Additionally, the survey provides detailed data on employment outcomes, including hours worked and job status, as well as the time spent on home production activities such as cooking, cleaning, and childcare.

Several other datasets are in the process to be added: the European Restructuring Monitor (Eurofound, 2025), which will allow us to identify mass layoff events (and thus leverage a more exogenous form of variation for our layoffs), and administrative data from the linked Censuses of England and Wales and the Annual Surveys of Hours and Earnings to improve precision. Further analysis will extend to Germany using the matched SOEP-CMI-ADIAB dataset (Caliendo et al., 2024; Antoni et al., 2023) to test whether these patterns persist in a more gender-conservative context.

In the micro-level analysis, we test for asymmetric household responses to layoffs, and for the correlation between this asymmetry and revealed gender norms. We employ an event study and a difference-in-differences approach, where the event is a layoff and the control group are couples in which neither partner is ever laid off in the sample. We compare how heterosexual households respond to a layoff depending on whether the person being laid off is the man or the woman, and then analyze how the reaction depends on the level of progressivity of the couple. The extent of reallocation of tasks across members of the couple can be a measure of how substitutable their inputs are in home production.

Simply comparing household responses to a male versus a female layoff reveals a striking pattern. Immediately after an involuntary layoff, in both cases the laid-off individuals raise housework time by a comparable amount, allowing their partner to reduce their housework; though in neither case that translates into an increase in hours worked by the partner. However, in the long run, an asymmetry opens up: five to ten years later most laid-off men have returned to paid work whereas a sizeable share of women remain non-employed, still performing elevated levels of housework.

This asymmetry is driven entirely by women who hold conservative gender attitudes. To identify whether this asymmetry is driven by gender norms, we split the sample between progressive and conservative couples. We measure progressiveness based on the answer to questions such as "how much do you agree or disagree with the statement: A pre-school child is likely to suffer if his or her mother works." We combine answers to four of these questions using principal component analysis, and dichotomize the resulting variable to classify individuals as "progressive" or "conservative". When we interact responses to layoffs with this dummy variable, we find that the entirety of the men-women long term asymmetry in labor market behavior is driven by conservative women: progressive women behave exactly like men.

Given the micro-estimates, we are in the process of developing a search and matching model to quantify the aggregate consequences of these frictions. The starting point is the search model of Faberman et al. (2022), which features endogenous search effort, on-the-job search, wage bargaining, and vacancy creation. We plan to extend their model to incorporate endogenously heterogeneous search effort across men and women. In our baseline framework, search effort by members of the couple is closely tied to the partners' substitutability in home production, and we will use the estimated micro-elasticities to discipline this search-and-matching model.

Ultimately, we will use the model to evaluate how the economy responds to business cycle shocks, counterfactually ask whether the recovery would be faster if households behaved as progressively as the most gender-egalitarian ones, and inform alternative policies for business cycle recovery. Crucially, the model will also allow us to consider the distribution of shocks across sectors and how men and women might be differently exposed to them in the first place. While recessions most commonly impact the manufacturing and construction sectors more, women tend to be employed in the services sector. However, if women do return to work at a slower pace than men, the aggregate recovery from services-led recessions such as the COVID pandemic would be particularly slow and most-likely warrant policy intervention.

Related Literature A substantial body of empirical work documents that, although in the last decades male and female labor market profiles have converged, material disparities persist, and they are particularly sharp when it comes to home production. In the United Kingdom, women still perform almost 80% more unpaid care and housework than men and supply about 30% fewer paid hours; in the United States, numbers are comparable (OECD, 2024). Evidence from developed countries shows that gender gaps in earnings are relatively small at labor market entry but widen sharply with the arrival of children, when the requirements of home production increase exponentially; in most OECD economies at least 40%, and usually the entirety, of the remaining earnings gap is now attributable to "motherhood penalties" (Kleven et al., 2024). These penalties cannot be rationalized by biology or static comparative advantage (Andresen and Nix, 2022) but map closely to spatial and cohort variation in gender-norm indicators (Kleven, 2022; Boelmann et al., 2025). Thus, understanding the division of home production, and the role of gender norms in how it is shared between partners, is crucial for explaining the remaining gender gaps in the labor market.

We contribute to this literature by showing that, while progress has been made in terms of female labor market participation - indeed, we do see that progressive women respond to labor market shocks in ways that are comparable to men's - the same cannot be said of the household: progressive women do almost as much home production as conservative women, and returning to work after a job loss does not translate into a decrease of home production, as it does for men, making "the squeeze" (Low, 2025) more binding.

A newer strand of research shows that couples willingly incur private income losses in order to uphold gender norms. Small fiscal or ranking perturbations - e.g. marginal tax-rate changes (Ichino et al., 2024) or spouse-based tax credits (Giommoni and Rubolino, 2022) - prompt shifts in time use that leave joint earnings below the feasible frontier. These studies, however, examine relatively low-stakes incentives. Whether the same normative frictions bind when households confront large, exogenous shocks remains largely unexplored. Understanding this margin is essential: if gender norms hinder efficient reallocation after layoffs, trade disruptions, or other macroeconomic shocks, both household welfare and aggregate recovery suffer. By focusing on severe employment shocks, the present project moves the literature from "micro nudges" to high-cost events, thereby testing whether norms merely shape the equilibrium allocation of labor or also impede its redeployment when economic circumstances change dramatically.

Our work also speaks to the literature on job loss (Jacobson et al., 1993). While a couple of papers have documented the unequal impact of job loss on men and women (Illing et al., 2024; Ivandi and Lassen, 2023), consistently with our findings, we are the first to map this asymmetry to gender norms and to analyze its implication for the aggregate economy.

The rest of the paper is organized as follows. In Section 2 we present a conceptual framework linking gender norms and households' choices of time use. In Section 3 we present the data and our variables' construction, and in Section 4 the methodology. Section 5 discusses the micro-level results on household responses to layoffs, and Section 6 introduces the search-and-matching model, augmented to account for gender norms. Section 7 concludes.

2 Conceptual Framework

In this section, we briefly outline a conceptual framework linking gender norms with household allocation of time use. This framework builds on Ichino et al. (2024).

Setup We assume that households maximize a joint utility function, U, which depends on two primary components: consumption (C) and a common household good (G):

$$U = U(C, G)$$

Consumption (C) is determined by the total income of the household, which is a function of paid labor by the male and female partners, weighted by their respective wages (w_f, w_m):

$$C = w_f W_f + w_m W_m$$

The household good (G) is produced using time inputs from both partners in home production:

$$G = f(H_f, H_m)$$

where H_f and H_m denote the hours spent on home production by the female and male partners, respectively. Each partner faces a time constraint:

$$T_g = W_g + H_g \quad \text{for } g = f, m$$

where T_g is the total time available, divided between paid work (W_g) and home production (H_g).

The Role of Gender Norms Gender norms are introduced into the framework as they influence the elasticity of substitution between H_f and H_m in the production of G. This elasticity serves as a proxy for the rigidity of gender norms: a symmetric, high elasticity indicates progressive norms, where male and female inputs are highly substitutable, allowing for flexible reallocation of tasks; an asymmetric, low elasticity indicates traditional norms, where substitution is limited, constraining the households ability to adapt to shocks. For example, in households with low elasticity of substitution, traditional gender norms may prevent men from taking on home production tasks, even when they are fully free from work. By contrast, households with high elasticity can reallocate tasks more efficiently, mitigating the effects of shocks on utility.

Gender norms, and thus the elasticity of substitution in this simple framework, not only impact the welfare of the couple, by determining the ability of the couple to weather negative economic shocks and to take advantage of positive economic shocks, but, at the aggregate level, constrained reallocation of labor in households with traditional norms may reduce the economys ability to recover from shocks.

2.1 Hypotheses

The are different ways to conceptualize how gender norms influence household responses to shocks and the hypothesis to be tested.

1. **Null Hypothesis:** Gender norms do not influence household responses to economic shocks. Men and women respond symmetrically to shocks, and household reallocation of labor and home production occurs efficiently.

2. **Alternative Hypotheses:**

   (a) **Short-Term Asymmetry:** Following a layoff, women increase home production to compensate for lost income, enabling their male partners to maintain or increase paid work. Men do not reciprocate this behavior when roles are reversed.

   (b) **Long-Term Asymmetry:** Men are more likely to return to the labor force after a layoff, while women remain out of paid employment and focus on home production.

We will see that, while we do not find support for the first, we do find substantial support for the second: women do return to work at a lower rate than men after a layoff, and this asymmetry is only present in traditional couples.

3 Data

To address the question of whether gender norms mediate household responses to economic shocks, we utilize longitudinal household survey data to estimate the effects of layoffs on labor supply, home production, and intra-household dynamics. In the future, we will complement this survey data with administrative employees records, as well as with detailed records of mass layoffs. The methodological approach combines event studies, difference-in-differences, and instrumental variable techniques to identify causal effects while accounting for heterogeneity in gender norms.

3.1 Data Sources

The primary data source for this study is the *Understanding Society* survey, a longitudinal household survey conducted in the United Kingdom since 1991 (University of Essex, Institute for Social and Economic Research, 2024). This nationally representative panel follows individuals and households over time, collecting detailed information on employment, time use, income, and attitudes toward gender roles. The survey includes all household members, allowing for a comprehensive analysis of intra-household dynamics. The *Understanding Society* dataset also includes questions about gender norms, which are used to construct a "progressiveness index" to classify individuals. This feature is critical for investigating whether the rigidity of gender norms influences household responses to shocks. Additionally, the survey provides detailed data on employment outcomes, such as hours worked and job status, as well as time spent on home production activities like cooking, cleaning, and childcare, and responsibility for such activities, which is crucial to define an "extensive margin" of home production.

We are in the process of merging this dataset with information of restructuring events from the European Restructuring Monitor (Eurofound, 2025), in order to identify which layoffs in our data are linked to restructuring events and are thus more plausibly exogenous.

Future analysis will include the comparable German *Socio-Economic Panel* (SOEP). These datasets enable cross-country comparisons between the UK and Germany, which differ substantially in the prevalence of traditional gender norms. Germany provides a more conservative gender norm context, while the UK is relatively progressive. These cross-country comparisons allow for an exploration of how cultural and institutional differences interact with economic shocks.

Finally, we plan to complement the analysis above with administrative data, in order to minimize measurement error and more credibly claim causality. For the UK, administrative data from the linked Censuses of England and Wales and the Annual Surveys of Hours and Earnings will allow us to minimize measurement error in earnings, and the ONS Business Structure Database will allow us to identify plan closures and mass layoff events. For Germany, we are in the process of applying to the matched SOEP-CMI-ADIAB dataset (Caliendo et al., 2024), which links the household survey data with administrative records.

3.2 Main Outcome Variables

Our main outcome variables measure paid work and home production, both on the intensive and on the extensive margin.

Labor market variables are quite straightforward: individuals are explicitly asked about labor force status and number of hours spent in paid work.

For home production, the measure of hours is direct, while the measure of the extensive margin is novel. Respondent are asked the number of hours spent in housework (e.g. cleaning, cooking, etc.), though this measure does not include childcare and is only asked biyearly, so for each individual we impute the missing years using the average of the two adjacent years. However, the same number of hours of home production can have a very different impact on welfare and productivity on the labor market depending on whether they also requires planning, being on call, etc.: the infamous “mental load”. This is the concept we capture with our extensive margin measure of home production. In particular, we do the following: in the survey, respondents are asked explicitly who does the cooking, who does the grocery, who does the cleaning, who does the washing; respondent can answer: it’s mostly me, we share equally, it’s mostly my partner. For each task, we create a dummy variable equal to 1 if the respondent answers “mostly me”, and 0 otherwise. We then average across tasks to obtain out extensive margin measure of home production (“Fraction of household tasks I am mainly responsible for”).

3.3 Economic Shocks: Layoffs

Layoff shocks are large, salient disruptions to an individuals employment. In the *Understanding Society* survey, layoffs are identified based on self-reported reasons for job loss, specifically responses indicating that the individual was "made redundant" or "dismissed/sacked." Layoffs provide a clear and immediate shock to household labor supply, making them a valuable setting for studying household responses. However, potential endogeneity concerns arise, as layoffs may be correlated with unobserved individual characteristics, such as poor job performance or pre-existing financial instability.

To address this issue, we are in the process of combining this survey with the European Restructuring Monitor (Eurofound, 2025), a database of restructuring events in Europe which will allow us to identify which of the identified layoffs are part of a mass layoff event, and thus in principle more exogenous to the worker than general layoffs.

3.4 Measuring Gender Norms

Gender norms are quantified using the level of agreement with the following statements:

- A pre-school child is likely to suffer if his or her mother works.
- All in all, family life suffers when the woman has a full-time job.
- Both the husband and wife should contribute to the household income.
- A husband's job is to earn money, a wife's job is to look after the home and family.

We aggregate the responses using principal component analysis (PCA) to construct a "progressiveness index." Individuals are classified as "progressive" or "traditional" based on whether their index score is above or below the median.

3.5 Sample restrictions

The analysis focuses on heterosexual couples, as same-sex couples constitute less than 1% of the sample, limiting statistical power. Individuals and couples with multiple layoffs are excluded to isolate the effects of single shocks. In the current analysis, we restrict to couples which remain married / cohabiting, though we plan to relax this restriction in future iterations.

4 Empirical Strategy

The empirical analysis combines event studies, difference-in-differences (DiD), and instrumental variable techniques to estimate the causal effects of economic shocks on household labor allocation.

For layoff shocks, we employ an event study and a difference-in-differences approach, where the event is a layoff and the control group are individuals who are never laid off in the sample. The specification is as follows:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_i + \delta_t + \beta_{h(i)} + \sum_{k=-5, k\neq -2}^{10} \gamma_k D_{it}^{(k)} + \epsilon_{it}, \tag{1}$$

where Y_{it} is the outcome of interest for individual i in year t, $D_{it}^{(k)}$ is a dummy variable equal to 1 if the individual is k years from experiencing a layoff, and α_i, δ_t and $\beta_{h(i)}$ are individual, time, and age fixed effects, respectively. In future iterations, we will instrument the layoff shocks with the mass layoff events collected in the Restructuring Monitor.

We also summarize the results in a simpler difference-in-differences specification:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_i + \delta_t + \beta_{h(i)} + \gamma^{SR}(\text{Post}_{it}^{SR} \times \text{Treatment}_i) + \gamma^{LR}(\text{Post}_{it}^{LR} \times \text{Treatment}_i) + \epsilon_{it} \tag{2}$$

where Treatment$_i$ is a dummy indicating whether the individual experienced a layoff, Post$_{it}^{SR}$ is a dummy indicating the year of the layoff and the following year, Post$_{it}^{LR}$ is a dummy indicating years 2 through 10 after a layoff.

We test for heterogeneous effects by gender norms by including an interaction between $Treatment_i$ (and both $Post^{SR}$ and $Post^{LR}$) with the dummy for being progressive, as described in Section 3.4.

5 Results: Evidence from Layoffs

In this section we show how households respond to layoffs, focusing on the effects of a layoff on the individual who experiences the shock and their partner. In what follows, we first show the impact of layoffs when a woman is laid off and how her partner responds, then the impact when a man is laid off and how his partner responds, and finally a direct comparison of the outcomes for men and women.

5.1 When a Woman is Laid Off

Figure 1 and Table 1 show what happens to a woman and her partner when she loses her job.

When a woman experiences a layoff, her paid work hours drop significantly, as shown in panel (a) of Figure 1. In the first column of Table 1 we see that on average, women reduce their weekly hours of paid employment by approximately 10 hours on impact (the year of the layoff and following), with a very partial recovery in the following years. In the long run (2 to 10 years after the layoff), women work approximately 7 fewer hours per week compared to pre-layoff levels. The reduction in paid work is accompanied by an increase in housework hours. Panel (b) of Figure 1 shows that women increase their weekly housework hours by approximately 1.6 hours immediately following the layoff, and this increase persists in the long run. This pattern indicates a reallocation of time from market work to home production.

The male partners of women who are laid off also adjust their behavior, albeit in limited ways. As shown in Figure 1, male partners reduce their housework contributions slightly, by about 0.6 hours per week in the long run, as detailed in Table 1 (Column 4). However, they do not significantly increase their own paid work hours, despite having more time available due to their reduced housework contributions. This limited response suggests a lack of compensatory adjustments by male partners in response to their female partners layoff. The division of household tasks also shifts following a womans layoff. Panel (c) of Figure 1 shows that women take on a greater share of household tasks (cooking, cleaning, washing, and grocery shopping), for which they report being "mostly responsible", allowing their partner to be responsible for fewer of them.

5.2 When a Man is Laid Off

The response to a man's layoff does not differ dramatically from that of a woman's, at least in the short run. As shown in Figure 2(a) and in Table 2, men reduce their weekly paid work hours by about 13 hours on impact (the year of the layoff and the following). Unlike women, however, men exhibit a steady recovery in employment over time. In the long-run, which we take as being the average in the years 2 through 10 after the layoff, men work approximately 6 fewer hours per week compared to their pre-layoff levels, indicating a stronger long-term recovery relative to women.

In terms of housework, men increase their contributions significantly following a layoff. Panel (b) of Figure 2 shows that men increase their weekly housework hours by approximately 1.4 hours in the short run, with a slight decline over the long run. This increase, though notable, is smaller than the reduction in their paid work hours, suggesting that some of their free time is allocated to leisure or other activities. The female partners of men who are laid off reduce their housework contributions by about 1 hour per week, as shown in Table 2 (Column 4). However, similar to male partners of laid-off women, these female partners do not significantly increase their paid work hours, as demonstrated in panel (a) of Figure 2 and Column 3 of Table 2. In terms of household tasks, panels (c) and (d) of Figure 2 indicate that men take on a greater share of responsibilities for tasks such as cooking, cleaning, and childcare following a layoff. However, their increased involvement in household tasks diminishes over time as they return to the labor market, demonstrating the temporary nature of this adjustment.

5.3 Comparison Between Men and Women

A direct comparison between men and women reveals important long-run asymmetries in how they and their households respond to layoffs. Panel (a) of Figure 3 shows that both men and women experience an immediate decline in employment following a layoff, but the long-term trajectories diverge sharply. Men are significantly more likely to return to the labor market, with their employment rates recovering steadily over time. By contrast, women exhibit a much lower probability of returning to work, with many remaining permanently out of the labor force.The persistence of these labor market differences is mirrored in household labor allocation. Panel (b) of Figure 3 shows that women's increased housework contributions following a layoff are more persistent than those of men. Women continue to bear a greater share of household responsibilities in the long run, whereas men's increased housework contributions fade as they reintegrate into the labor market. These gendered patterns suggest that traditional gender norms might play a significant role in shaping household responses to layoffs. Women are more likely to assume additional domestic responsibilities and less likely to reenter the labor force, reinforcing traditional divisions of labor. Men, on the other hand, exhibit stronger labor market recovery and a more temporary adjustment to household tasks.

Partners of laid-off individuals adjust their housework contributions but do not significantly change their labor market behavior.

5.4 Heterogeneity by Gender Norms

The role of gender norms in driving these asymmetries is evident when analyzing heterogeneity across households with different levels of progressiveness. Households are classified as progressive or traditional based on their responses to survey questions about gender roles, as described in the methodology. In progressive households, as shown in Table 3, women are significantly more likely to return to the labor market after a layoff compared to women in traditional households:

Column 1 shows that progressive women close the employment gap with men, with their long-term reemployment rates resembling those of their male counterparts (displayed in column 1 of Table 4). This finding underscores the importance of progressive gender norms in mitigating labor market scarring for women. For men, responses to layoffs are relatively similar across progressive and traditional households, as shown in Table 4. Regardless of household norms, men exhibit a relatively strong labor market recovery. This symmetry in male responses suggests that gender norms primarily affect womens labor market outcomes, rather than those of men.

However, while progressive women do return to the labor market after a layoff, they don't symmetrically reduce their responsibility for household tasks. While progressiveness helps women close the gap in the labor market, it does not seem to do the same within the household.

6 A Search Model With Gender Norms

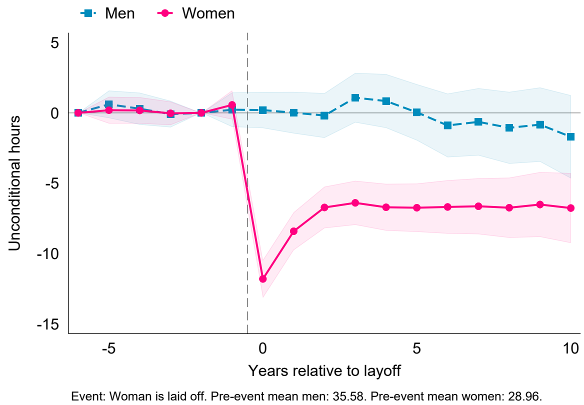
In progress

7 Conclusion

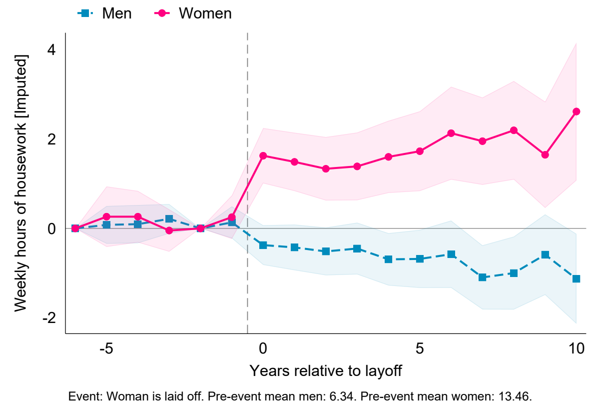
This paper contributes to our understanding of how households respond to economic shocks by highlighting the central role of gender norms. The findings demonstrate that traditional norms reinforce gendered patterns of labor market adjustment and household labor allocation, with significant implications for womens long-term economic outcomes. Progressive households exhibit more equitable responses in the labor market, with women returning to the labor force at rates comparable to men, though not in the household. These results suggest that gender norms might be a critical barrier to the efficient reallocation of resources in response to economic shocks, and that a more progressive society might make both households and the economy as a whole more resilient to economic shocks.

Figures

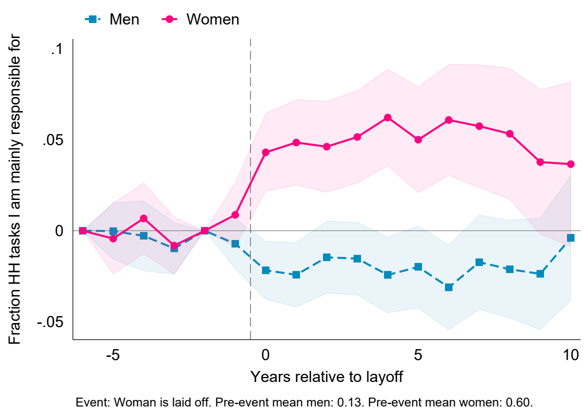
Figure 1: Responses To Woman's Layoff



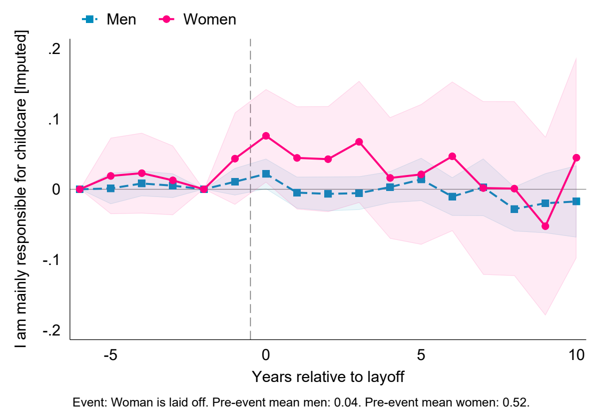
(a) Weekly hours in paid employment



(b) Weekly hours in housework



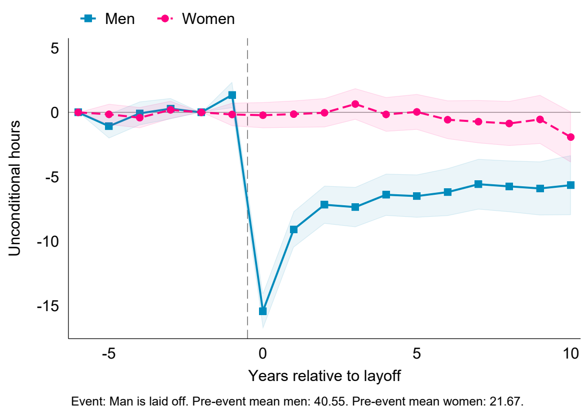
(c) Fraction of household tasks I am mainly responsible for



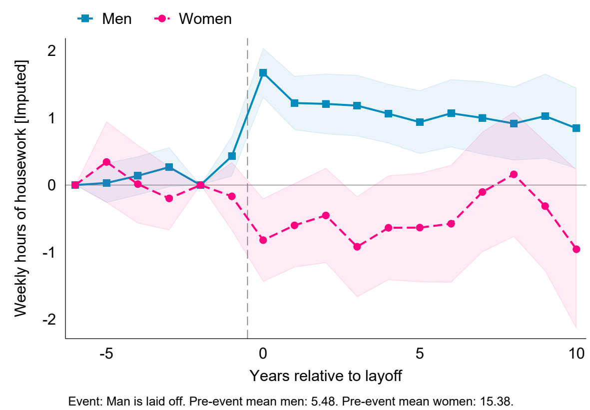
(d) I am mainly responsible for childcare

Notes: The figure shows estimated coefficients on relative-time dummies from running the event-study specification in (1), where the event is the layoff of the woman in a couple. The circles in pink (connected by the solid line) correspond to the estimates for the woman, the squares in blue (connected by the dashed line) correspond to the estimates for her male partner. The outcomes are: in panel (a), the number of weekly hours spent in paid employment; in panel (b), the number of weekly hours spent doing housework; in panel (c), "fraction of household tasks I am mainly responsible for", constructed as the average of four dummies for responding "mostly me" to the questions "who is responsible for doing the groceries/cooking/cleaning/washing?"; in panel (d), a dummy for answering "mostly me" to the question "who is responsible for childcare". Data: United Kingdom's *Understanding Society*, 1991-2019. The sample includes individuals aged 15 and older. The estimation includes individual, time, and age fixed effects.

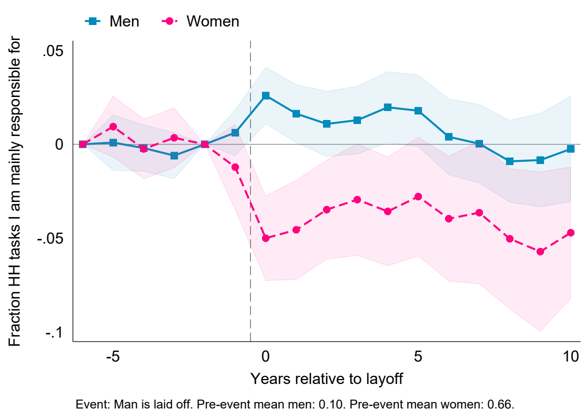
Figure 2: Responses To Man's Layoff



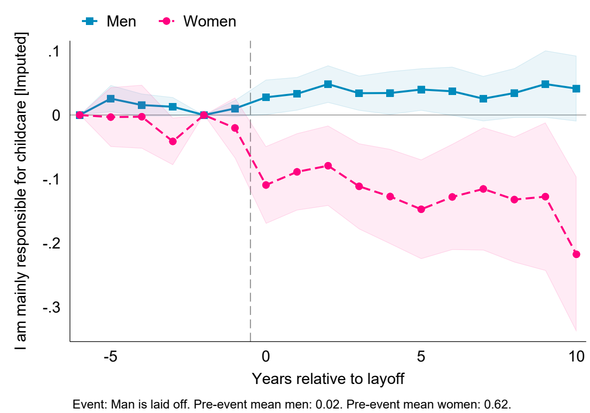
(a) Weekly hours in paid employment



(b) Weekly hours in housework



(c) Fraction of household tasks I am mainly responsible for

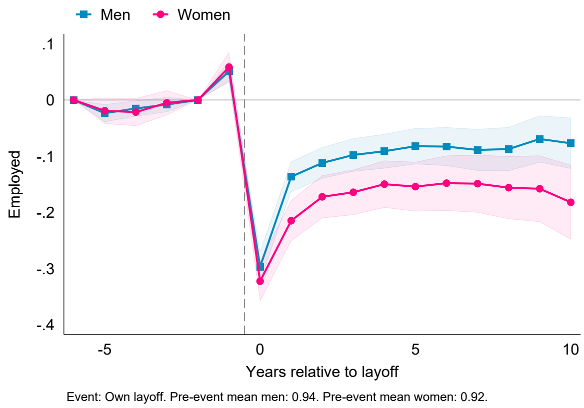


(d) I am mainly responsible for childcare

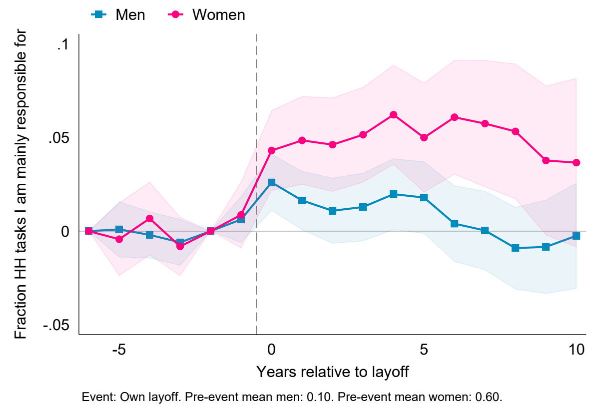
Notes: The figure shows estimated coefficients on relative-time dummies from running the event-study specification in (1), where the event is the layoff of the man in a couple. The circles in blue (connected by a solid line) correspond to the estimates for the man, the squares in pink (connected by a dashed line) correspond to the estimates for the female partner. The outcomes are: in panel (a), the number of weekly hours spent in paid employment; in panel (b), the number of weekly hours spent doing housework; in panel (c), "fraction of household tasks I am mainly responsible for", constructed as the average of four dummies for responding "mostly me" to the questions "who is responsible for doing the groceries/cooking/cleaning/washing?"; in panel (d), a dummy for answering "mostly me" to the question "who is responsible for childcare". Data: United Kingdom *Understanding Society*, 1991-2019. The sample includes individuals aged 15 and older. The estimation includes individual, time, and age fixed effects.

Figure 3: Comparing Men's and Women's Responses to Own and Partner's Layoff

Own Layoff

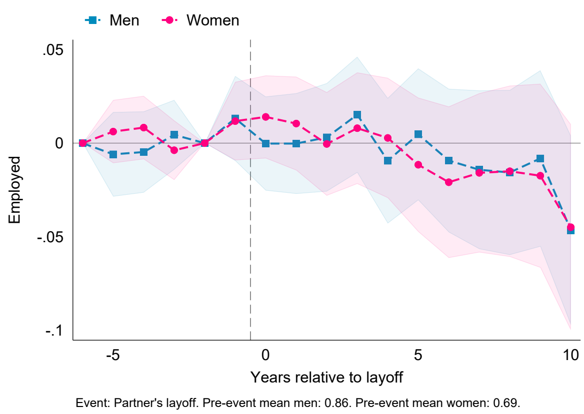


(a) Employment (Own layoff)

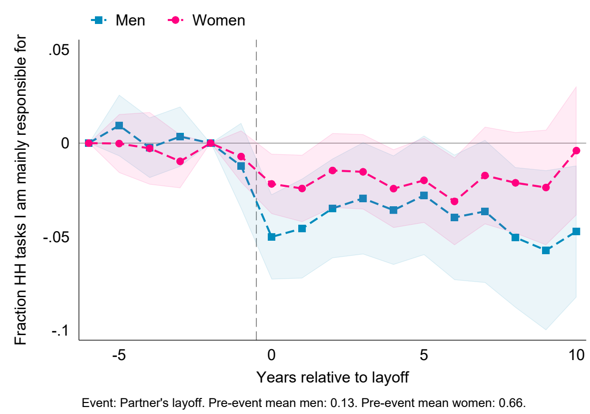


(b) Housework (Own layoff)

Partner's Layoff



(c) Employment (Partner's layoff)



(d) Housework (Partner's layoff)

Notes: The figure shows estimated coefficients on relative-time dummies from running the event-study specification in (1). In panels (a) and (b) the event is own layoff; in panels (c) and (d) the event is partner's layoff. The squares in blue correspond to the estimates for men, the circles in pink correspond to the estimates for women; solid lines (in panels a and b) indicate responses to own layoff, while dashed lines (in panels c and d) indicate responses to partner's layoff. The outcomes are: in panels (a) and (c), a dummy for being in paid employment; in panels (b) and (d) "fraction of household tasks I am mainly responsible for", constructed as the average of four dummies for responding "mostly me" to the questions "who is responsible for doing the groceries/cooking/cleaning/washing?". Data: United Kingdom *Understanding Society*, 1991-2019. The sample includes individuals aged 15 and older. The estimation includes individual, time, and age fixed effects.

Tables

Table 1: Responses To Woman's Layoff

	Own		Partner's	
	Paid Work	Housework	Paid Work	Housework
Post-Layoff SR	-10.63***	1.603***	-0.465	-0.347
	(0.649)	(0.328)	(0.571)	(0.212)
Post-Layoff LR	-7.023***	1.534***	-0.171	-0.592*
	(0.698)	(0.380)	(0.726)	(0.242)
Pre-layoff mean	28.90	13.89	37.98	6.233
N	129346	118128	116120	111855
N (Individuals)	16916	15466	15647	14784

Standard errors in parentheses

$^{+}$ $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Notes: Outcomes are measured in hours per week. Short-run (SR) indicates the year of the layoff and the following; Long-run (LR) indicates years 2 through 10 after the layoff. All regressions include individual, year, and age fixed effects. Errors are clustered at the individual level.

Table 2: Responses To Man's Layoff

	Own		Partner's	
	Paid Work	Housework	Paid Work	Housework
Post-Layoff SR	-12.84***	1.370***	-0.0895	-0.827**
	(0.636)	(0.180)	(0.448)	(0.277)
Post-Layoff LR	-6.480***	1.028***	0.401	-0.719*
	(0.667)	(0.202)	(0.544)	(0.317)
Pre-layoff mean	41.32	5.344	22.37	15.76
N	121378	117296	134552	122820
N (Individuals)	16332	15437	17579	16081

Standard errors in parentheses

$^{+}$ $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Notes: Outcomes are measured in hours per week. Short-run (SR) indicates the year of the layoff and the following; Long-run (LR) indicates years 2 through 10 after the layoff. All regressions include individual, year, and age fixed effects. Errors are clustered at the individual level.

Table 3: Responses To Woman's Layoff: interaction with Progressiveness

	Own		Partner's	
	Employed	Housework Tasks	Employed	Housework Tasks
Post-Layoff SR	-0.314***	0.0422**	-0.00827	-0.0273*
	(0.0286)	(0.0154)	(0.0171)	(0.0109)
Post-Layoff LR	-0.238***	0.0474**	-0.0190	-0.0366**
	(0.0298)	(0.0172)	(0.0224)	(0.0128)
Post-Layoff SR	0.0642+	-0.00801	0.00793	0.0172
× Progressive	(0.0354)	(0.0203)	(0.0219)	(0.0150)
Post-Layoff LR	0.132***	-0.00879	0.000805	0.0384*
× Progressive	(0.0360)	(0.0227)	(0.0280)	(0.0177)
Pre-layoff mean (Progressive=0)	0.869	0.665	0.888	0.108
Pre-layoff mean (Progressive=1)	0.920	0.568	0.901	0.139
N	133762	114520	131046	107874
N (Individuals)	16362	14858	16199	13938

Standard errors in parentheses

$^{+}$ $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Notes: The event is a woman's layoff. Columns (1) and (2) report own outcomes, while columns (3) and (4) report partner's outcomes. The outcomes are: in columns (1) and (3), a dummy for being in paid employment; in columns (2) and (4) "fraction of household tasks I am mainly responsible for", constructed as the average of four dummies for responding "mostly me" to the questions "who is responsible for doing the groceries/cooking/cleaning/washing?". Short-run (SR) indicates the year of the layoff and the following; Long-run (LR) indicates years 2 through 10 after the layoff. "Progressive" is a dummy for individuals with above-median progressiveness, as defined in the text. All regressions include individual, year, and age fixed effects. Errors are clustered at the individual level.

Table 4: Responses To Man's Layoff: interaction with Progressiveness

	Own		Partner's	
	Employed	Housework Tasks	Employed	Housework Tasks
Post-Layoff SR	-0.254***	0.0230**	-0.0117	-0.0578***
	(0.0167)	(0.00795)	(0.0157)	(0.0108)
Post-Layoff LR	-0.116***	0.0129	0.000177	-0.0507***
	(0.0170)	(0.00910)	(0.0191)	(0.0123)
Post-Layoff SR	0.0539*	0.00129	0.0159	0.00931
× Progressive	(0.0247)	(0.0126)	(0.0229)	(0.0178)
Post-Layoff LR	0.0320	0.00211	0.00759	0.0182
× Progressive	(0.0250)	(0.0142)	(0.0277)	(0.0200)
Pre-layoff mean (Progressive=0)	0.947	0.0879	0.637	0.709
Pre-layoff mean (Progressive=1)	0.954	0.109	0.812	0.591
N	135254	113937	136121	116149
N (Individuals)	16422	14760	16409	14769

Standard errors in parentheses

$^{+}$ $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Notes: The event is a man's layoff. Columns (1) and (2) report own outcomes, while columns (3) and (4) report partner's outcomes. The outcomes are: in columns (1) and (3), a dummy for being in paid employment; in columns (2) and (4) "fraction of household tasks I am mainly responsible for", constructed as the average of four dummies for responding "mostly me" to the questions "who is responsible for doing the groceries/cooking/cleaning/washing?". Short-run (SR) indicates the year of the layoff and the following; Long-run (LR) indicates years 2 through 10 after the layoff. "Progressive" is a dummy for individuals with above-median progressiveness, as defined in the text. All regressions include individual, year, and age fixed effects. Errors are clustered at the individual level.

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